

Writing model

You are going to learn the difference between the past perfect and simple past and how to link paragraphs in an essay. You are then going to use these skills to write the story of an important invention or discovery that changed the world.

A Model

Read the model and use the information to complete the table below.

Like many other inventions, the microwave was based on technology that people had previously used for other purposes. The ability of microwaves to conduct heat was accidentally discovered by Percy Spencer. He had been working with radars when he found that the heat from them melted the candy bar in his pocket. From this he discovered that microwaves could be used to cook food. His company had registered the idea by 1945, but they didn't sell microwaves to the public until early 1947. At first, microwaves were very big and expensive, but they went on to create a revolution in the kitchen.

As soon as microwaves became cheaper and smaller it meant more people could buy them. Today microwaves are very common and easy to locate, but some people have been concerned about the health impact of microwaves. As soon as microwaves had been built and sold cheaply there was a sharp rise in the number of processed meals available. Eating enough of these will eventually have a negative impact on your health. However, cooking fresh foods such as vegetables in a microwave is as healthy as any other cooking method and much faster.

B Analyze

Invention / discovery	How	Effect
compass	by the Chinese using a natural magnet between the 9 th and 11 th century CE	increased trade and helped people to explore more countries
telephone	1876 by Alexander Graham Bell. Used existing technology	made communication much faster
microwave		

Read the model and the Analyze table again and answer the questions with a partner.

- 1 Why was the microwave an important invention?
- 2 Which invention in the table do you think was the most important? Why?

Past perfect and simple past

Use the **past perfect** to talk about an action in the past that was completed before another action in the past. The **simple past** is used to talk about a past habit, event, and state.

heat **had touched** the candy bar
(earlier past moment)

the candy bar **melted**
(past moment)

today

Form	Examples
Past perfect	
had / hadn't + past participle	alphabets and writing had started to grow Amundsen hadn't planned to go to the South Pole.
Simple past	
subject + verb + -ed	From this he discovered that microwaves could be used to cook food.
subject + did not (didn't) + base form	they didn't sell microwaves to the public until early 1947.
Irregular verbs do not follow a pattern. You have to memorize them.	fall → fell

1 Complete the sentences using the past perfect form of the verbs in parentheses.

- Before the invention of the telephone, people _____ (communicate) largely by letter.
- They _____ (realize) the importance of their invention until it changed the way people communicated.
- Tim Berners-Lee created the World Wide Web in 1989. However, the writer Arthur C. Clarke _____ (predict) a similar idea in the 1970s.
- It _____ (take) days to travel across the country.
- Percy Spencer discovered the microwave when he realized his machine _____ (cook) the food in his pocket.
- The company _____ (sell) over a million by the end of the decade.



2 Choose the correct option to complete each sentence.

- 1 In 1988, no one **heard / had heard** of the Internet. Twenty years later billions of people **used / had used** it.
- 2 Before the invention of e-mail, people **waited / had waited** days for letters to arrive.
- 3 In 1950, 80% of Britons **had not had / didn't have** a car, but by 2000 80% **had / had had** a car.
- 4 In 2015, people **sent / had sent** 16 million texts per minute. No one **had ever sent / sent** a text message before 1992.
- 5 The invention of the airplane **had made / made** it much quicker to travel around the world.

3 Complete the sentences with the appropriate form of the past perfect or simple past.

- 1 I _____ (hear) of a video player until my grandfather showed me one.
- 2 When my grandfather was a child most people _____ (have) a television.
- 3 My father _____ (use) a computer by the time he was 20 years old. I used one much younger, at three years old.
- 4 I opened my e-mail account in 2014. Before that I _____ (send) a message to anyone.
- 5 When the company _____ (start), the owners _____ (invent) two new products.
- 6 Before 2006 no one _____ (use) the website. Now hundreds of people visit it every day.

4 Write about these situations in either the simple past or past perfect and the words in parentheses.

- 1 You went on vacation with your friend. It was her first flight.
(friend / never / fly) _____
- 2 Your grandfather got his first smartphone for his birthday.
(not / use / birthday) _____
- 3 There was a new IT system. After two weeks, everyone could use it.
(everyone / able to use / two weeks) _____
- 4 She didn't see many wild animals. Then she went to South Africa.
(see / until / South Africa) _____